Vera's Journey: What Was the Kindertransport?

Key Enquiry Question: How did 10,000 child refugees escape to Britain, and what was inside their suitcases?

LESSON 03
WORKSHEET 1



Source A: *Jewish refugee girls descending the gangway of a passenger ship upon arrival in London port in February 1939, wearing official numbered registration cards around their necks. (Bundesarchiv Bild 183-S69279)*

HISTORICAL READING • VERA'S ESCAPE

In 1938, as Nazi persecution spread across Europe, Jewish families faced a heartbreaking choice. To save their children from danger, parents made the agonizing decision to send them alone to safety in Britain. Between December 1938 and September 1939, a rescue mission called the **Kindertransport** ('children's transport') brought nearly **10,000 child refugees** to the UK.

Nine-year-old **Vera Schaufeld** was one of those children. She packed one small leather suitcase, hung a numbered cardboard label around her neck, and said goodbye to her parents at Prague station. Brave volunteers like **Sir Nicholas Winton** organized trains, found British foster families, and saved 669 Czech children.

TASK 1: ARTIFACT DETECTIVE • THE NUMBERED NECK TAG

Primary Source Skills



Source B: *Original Kindertransport neck tag (July 1939, Refugee Nr. 8434, Hilfsverein der Juden).*

1. Why did every refugee child have a large numbered tag tied around their neck with string?

2. Imagine arriving in London speaking no English. How did this tag help a child find safety?

TASK 2: ACTIVE CHRONOLOGICAL CHALLENGE • VERA'S JOURNEY ACROSS EUROPE

Chronological Sequencing & Empathy

STAGE 1 • THE PLATFORM
Prague Station (May 1939)
Parents wave goodbye behind barriers, hiding tears so their children wouldn't panic as the train pulled away.

Why was saying goodbye at the station the hardest moment?

STAGE 2 • THE CROSSING
Train & Ferry to Holland
A long, quiet journey across Germany, crossing into Holland where Dutch women gave them hot cocoa.

How did the hot cocoa show children they were safe?

STAGE 3 • LONDON ARRIVAL
Liverpool Street Station
Stepping into a noisy hall of strangers, waiting in the station to meet their British foster families.

How did British volunteers know which child to meet?

TASK 3: HISTORICAL INQUIRY • THE KINDERTRANSPORT PACKING DILEMMA & HEARTBREAK

Historical Empathy & Dilemma

*Strict Nazi regulations permitted each child to bring only **ONE small suitcase** (no valuables, no money over 10 Marks). Explain what was packed and why each choice was emotionally heartbreaking (Refer to your full-page refugee suitcase drawing on Sheet 3):*

1. Family Photograph Album & Handwritten Letters from Parents — SACRED MEMORY

Why was a family photograph often the single most precious and heartbreaking possession a child carried?

2. German-English Pocket Phrasebook & Translation Dictionary — SURVIVAL & LANGUAGE

Why was carrying a phrasebook vital for a 9-year-old child arriving alone in London speaking zero English?

3. Warm Woollen Winter Coat, Underclothing & Sturdy Walking Shoes — PRACTICAL NECESSITY

Why did parents pack warm, durable clothing knowing they might not be able to send parcels later?

4. Small Religious or Cultural Keepsake (e.g. Rosary Beads or Prayer Book) — HERITAGE & IDENTITY

Why did Vera pack rosary beads given to her by her nanny before boarding the train in Prague?

5. Farewell Gift from a Childhood Friend (e.g. Carved Wooden Heart from Arnošt) — FRIENDSHIP & FAREWELL

How did packing a small keepsake from a friend help a child remember their pre-war childhood?

TASK 4: "THINKING HEADS" • CONTRASTING PERSPECTIVES

Historical Empathy

1 Vera (Age 9 • The Child Refugee)

What thoughts and feelings might Vera have as the train leaves Prague?

2 Sir Nicholas Winton (The Upstander)

What thoughts might motivate an upstander like Nicholas Winton to act?

THE BIG COMPARISON • YEAR 5 HISTORICAL SYNTHESIS

How was Vera's journey on the Kindertransport **similar to**, and **different from**, British children evacuated from London to the countryside?

ONE KEY SIMILARITY (BOTH EVACUATIONS)

ONE MAJOR DIFFERENCE (THE REFUGEE REALITY)

RTRANSPORT REFUGEE SUITCASE • VERA'S JOURNEY (1938–1939)

na: Strict Nazi Regulation: Each child was allowed only ONE suitcase. No valuables. No money over 10 Marks. Draw and label the 5 most precious items you would our family.

LESSON 03
SUITCASE CRAFT

REFUGEE NO. 8434 (VERA)
PRAG-HBF • GESTAPO ZUGELASSEN

OPEN REFUGEE SUITCASE CANVAS • DRAW, COLOR & PACK VERA'S CHERISHED POSSESSIONS HERE

Draw and arrange Vera's family photographs, warm clothes, dictionary, keepsake, and cherished memories freely inside her suitcase.